

Session 6: Abram the Snake

Key Takeaways

- Avram does not trust God and instead crafts a scheme that exposes Sarai to risk in order to preserve his own life.
- Rather than bringing blessing to the nations, Avram's schemes bring curses upon the Egyptians.
- This episode is set on analogy to Genesis 3 with Sarai in the role of the tree, Pharaoh and the Egyptians in the role of the humans, and Avram in the role of the snake.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 12:10-20

Introduction: Avram Goes to Egypt Because of a Famine

- a 10 Now there was a **famine in the land** ;
b and Avram went down to Egypt to sojourn there,
a' for the **famine** was severe **in the land** .

Avram Nears Egypt + Avram's Speech to Sarai

- 11 And it came about when he came near to entering Egypt,
and he said to Sarai his wife,
"See now, I know that you are **a woman beautiful of sight** ;
12 and **when the Egyptians see you** , **they will say** , '**This is his wife** ' ;
and they will kill me, but they will let you live.
13 Please **say that you are my sister** so that **there will be good to me on account of you** ,
and that I may live on account of you."

Egyptians See Sarai and Pharaoh Takes Her

- 14 And it came about when Avram came into Egypt,
and **the Egyptians saw that the woman was very beautiful** .
15 And Pharaoh's officials **saw her** and praised her to Pharaoh;
and the woman was **taken** into Pharaoh's house.
16 And **he did good to Avram on account of her** ;
and there was for him sheep and oxen and donkeys and male and female servants and female donkeys and camels.

Plagues on Pharaoh + Pharaoh's Speech to Avram

- 17 And Yahweh plagued Pharaoh and his house with great plagues on account of Sarai, **Avram's wife**.
- 18 And Pharaoh called Avram and he said,
"What is this you have done to me? **Why did you not tell me that she was your wife?**"
- 19 **Why did you say, 'She is my sister,'** so that I took her for **my wife?**
Now then, here is **your wife**, take her and go."

Conclusion: Avram Sent Away From Egypt by Pharaoh

- 20 And Pharaoh commanded his men concerning him;
and they sent him away, with his wife and all that belonged to him.

Genesis 12:10-20. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Genesis 12:10

A - Introduction: Avram Goes to Egypt Because of a Famine

Genesis 12:11-13

B - Avram Nears Egypt + **Avram's Speech to Sarai**

- "I know that you are a woman (אשה) beautiful of sight, very ... Please say that you are my sister (אחות)."

Genesis 12:14-16

C - Egyptians See Sarai and Pharaoh Takes Her

Genesis 12:17-19

B' - Plagues on Pharaoh + **Pharaoh's Speech to Avram**

- "Why did you say 'She is my sister (אחות),' so that I took her to be my wife (אשה)?"

Genesis 12:20

A' - Conclusion: Avram Sent Away From Egypt by Pharaoh

Genesis 12:10-20. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

A Crisis of Faith

God just promised Avram that traveling to the land of Canaan will result in blessing, abundance, and possession of the land, and this blessing will overflow into blessing for the nations. The first story we're told

after Avram’s obedient sojourn to Canaan is about Avram’s lack of trust and his deception of the nations that leads to curse and plagues upon them.

However, Avram’s deception is motivated by an understandable feeling. After going to a land where he was promised abundance, he discovers scarcity in a time of famine. The famine is Avram’s second test of faith. Will he remain in the land and trust God, or will he make up his own plan and attempt to find blessing and abundance by his own wisdom?

Avram’s “Wife-Sister” Plan

There is a cultural reason why Avram would come up with this specific scheme presenting Sarai as his sister. First, it is a half-truth, as Avram admits in 20:12, because Sarai is his half-sister from his father’s side. Marrying one’s step-sister was not uncommon in ancient Near Eastern cultures (in fact, it’s what Avram’s brother Nakhor did, see 11:29). But second, by presenting himself as Sarai’s brother, Avram was using a common cultural convention as an attempt to save his life and Sarai’s.

“In the ancient Near East there was a well-known socio-legal institution of ‘fratriarchy’ that existed over a long period of time. Where there is no father, the brother assumes legal guardianship of his sister, particularly with respect to obligations and responsibilities in arranging marriage on her behalf. Therefore, whoever wished to take Sarai to wife would have to negotiate with her ‘brother.’ In this way, Abram could gain time to plan escape. Of course, this went awry when the Egyptian turned out to be Pharaoh himself.”

Sarna, Nahum M. (2001). [The JPS Torah Commentary: Genesis](#). Jewish Publication Society. 95.

From this angle, Avram’s motivations appear both clever and foolish, but not malicious. His initial plan was aimed at preserving his and Sarai’s lives, because any Egyptian who proposed to Sarai would have to respect her brother. If he were known as her husband, he would more likely be the object of jealousy. This helps us see that [Genesis 12:14](#) actually vindicates Avram’s plan, as Egyptians see her. So far so good. But his plan does not account for the possibility that the king of all the land might “see” and “take” Sarai.

Avram the Snake

Genesis 12:10-20 is Avram’s “Eden failure.” The entire episode is set on analogy with the the snake’s deception of Adam and Eve. The analogies are surprising and offer important commentary on the character’s motives and actions.

Avram’s Deception in Genesis 12:10-20	The Snake’s Deception in Genesis 3
Avram relies on his knowledge of what will happen in Egypt instead of trusting God’s promise	Adam and Eve seek their own knowledge of good and bad, instead of trusting God’s command
Gen. 12:11-12 “I know (ידע) that a woman (אשה)	Gen. 3:6 The woman (האשה, Eve [חוה]) saw (ראה)
Avram the Snake. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

Avram's Deception in Genesis 12:10-20

beautiful of sight (מראה) you are ... and **they will see you** (ראה) ... and kill me and let you live (חיה)."

Avram's deception results in "good" at the expense of Sarai, resulting in plagues on Pharaoh

Gen. 12:13 "Say you're my sister, so that it may be **good** (יטב), **on account of you** (בעבורך), and I will **live** (חיה)."

Gen. 12:17 And Yahweh sent plagues upon Pharaoh, **on account of Sarai** .

Avram presents his wife as a "tree of testing" to the Egyptians

Gen. 12:14-15 And the Egyptians **saw** (ראה) **the woman** (האשה), **that she was beautiful, very ...** and **she was taken** (לקח) to the house of Pharaoh.

Gen. 12:17 And Yahweh **struck/touched** (נגע) Pharaoh with great **strikes** (נגעים).

Pharaoh holds Avram accountable for his deception

Gen. 12:18 And Pharaoh **called out to** (וִיקְרָא ... לֵ) Avram and said **"What is this you have done** (מה זאת עשית) to me? You didn't **tell** (נגד) me that she was your wife."

Pharaoh exiles Avram

Gen. 12:20 And Pharaoh **commanded** (וִיצַו) ... and **sent him away** (שלח).

The Snake's Deception in Genesis 3

) the tree of **knowing** (ידע) good (טוב) and evil, and it was desirable **to the eyes** .

Adam and Eve's actions result in "curse" on the ground

Gen. 3:17 Cursed is the ground **on account of you** (בעבורך).

The snake presents the "tree of testing" to the humans

Gen. 3:6 And **the woman** (האשה) **saw** (ראה) that **good** (טוב) was the tree for eating, and desirable **to the eyes ...** and **she took** (לקח) ..."

Gen. 3:3 "From the tree that is in the middle of the garden we cannot eat from it or **touch it** (נגע)"

God holds Adam and Eve accountable for their action

Gen. 3:9 And Yahweh **called out to** (וִיקְרָא ... אֶל) the man ...

Gen. 3:13 And Yahweh said to the woman, **"What is this you have done** (מה זאת עשית)?"

Gen. 3:11 "Who **told** (נגד) you that you were naked?"

God exiles Adam and Eve

Gen. 2:16 And Yahweh **commanded** (וִיצַו) the human ...

Avram the Snake. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Avram's Deception in Genesis 12:10-20

The Snake's Deception in Genesis 3

Gen. 3:23 And Yahweh **sent away** (שלח) the human from the garden of Eden.

Avram the Snake. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Implications of These Analogies

Avram is depicted on analogy to the shrewd snake. He is crafty, and he is able to use his circumstances to his own advantage, but at the expense of others. Avram's decision to lie puts Sarai in danger while also bringing plagues upon Pharaoh. In this scene, Avram's prosperity (= blessing) comes precisely through the suffering of the others.

Sarai's beauty is set in relationship to the beauty of the tree of testing in the garden of Eden. A good thing becomes co-opted by deceivers and used for their own advantage.

Notice that Pharaoh's role in the story activates two analogies.

1. Pharaoh on analogy to Adam and Eve: Pharaoh is innocent, yet he still commits wrong. While his "taking" of a woman is certainly an exercise in patriarchal power and privilege, he is portrayed as faultless in terms of his motives. But his innocent motives don't erase the fact that he's taking another man's wife.
2. Pharaoh on analogy to God: After Pharaoh finds out about Avram's deception, he takes on the divine role of holding Avram accountable.

God's Promise and God's Justice

This story presents an uncomfortable portrait of God's relationship to the nations. God defends the deceiver in this story and brings judgment on someone who has acted wrongly but without wrong motives. This chapter begins a long drama of tension between God's covenant promises to the family of Abraham and the divine character traits of justice and equity.

God just promised to "bless those who bless you and curse those who treat you as cursed." In this story we see God protecting Avram even though he doesn't deserve it. God's promises place him in a morally inconvenient situation.

"[Abram's behavior] would appear to put Yahweh in somewhat of a bind ... Yahweh must decide whether and how to take Abram's side when problems arise with others—even when the conflict arises from Abram's less-than-honest behavior. Pharaoh treats Abram honorably and generously, but Yahweh evidently decides that having a human friend in a wicked world requires a thoroughgoing commitment to the welfare of that individual, even when it works against the welfare of others. Standing with someone inevitably leads to standing against someone else. Yahweh, therefore, strikes Pharaoh and his household, even though the mess was made by Abram ... This first act of divine violence after the flood is momentous, as it is directed

toward people who have not, to the best of their knowledge, acted wickedly, for the sake of demonstrating solidarity with the family Yahweh has befriended.”

Hawk, L. Daniel (2019). [*The Violence of the Biblical God*](#). Eerdmans. 48-49.

Avram's Egyptian Plunder

This story also sets up a number of themes that will be developed in future episodes.

- Avram's lack of trust in God's protection and promise. This will be addressed again in chapter 15.
- Avram's short-sighted schemes to get or retain God's blessing by his own wisdom. This will replay itself again in chapters 16, 21, and 22.
- Avram's "plunder" consists of animal flocks and slaves, both of which will cause problems in later stories.

Genesis 12:16 Instructor's Translation

And [Pharaoh] did good to Avram on account of her;
and there was for him **sheep and oxen and donkeys** (the source of problems in Gen. 13)
and male and **female servants** (the source of problems in Gen. 16)
and female **donkeys and camels** (the source of problems in Gen. 13).

Reflection Question

How does the Genesis 12:10-20 mirror Genesis 3? How does this help us understand the meaning of this story?